close how he prepares and approaches things. You get to learn a lot."

As much as *The Family Man* is about an ordinary man balancing daredevil adventures at work against awkward conversations and conflicts at home, for many the heart of the show is the lively rapport between Tiwari and his workmate JK (the delightfully charming Sharib Hazmi). So much so that in season three, JK is positioned alongside Tiwari's family in one of the key posters. "He's the default member of it, that's how we treated him," says Krishna DK. "The banter comes naturally to them, but this season we tackle what is it that JK wants in life—and that's companionship." Prod Bajpayee on how he builds the bromance and he brings up how they rehearse the scene many times. "He [Sharib] gets *pakaoed* [bored]," laughs Bajpayee.

Bajpayee's intensive preparation generates both admiration and amusement among the directing duo and cast. Krishna notes how Sharib is the one "joking and blabbering" until "Action" is uttered, while Manoj tries to "stay in character". Raj talks of how the actor now runs his own "Bajpayee Institute of Acting" on set where all co-actors rehearse with him and get used to his improvisations. "He doesn't tell us what he wants to do. He wants to surprise us all the time," says Raj, with a cheeky smile. It is surprises that diehard fans of the show will want as they tune in for another round of Tiwari's action-packed life. ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA ▶

A Twist In the Tale

Ananyabrata Chakraborty's *Kaisi Ye Paheli* is a darkly comic murder mystery rooted in a mother-son bond





After making waves at global festivals, writer-director Ananyabrata Chakravorty's debut feature, *Kaisi Ye Paheli*, will hit the big screens in India on November 28. For Chakravorty, the film's journey has come full circle—beginning as a crowd-funded project, doing the international festival circuits, and now culminating in a theatrical release.

Set against the hills of the Northeast, *Kaisi Yeh Paheli* is a dark comedy-cum-murder mystery that revolves around a mother-son relationship. Chakravorty says it began as an exploration of loneliness and ageing, and "his own inability to truly connect with his mother". "To make it more interesting, I arrived at a murder mystery—where a mother has to solve a crime just to get her son to talk to her. The dark comedy comes from how her presence exposes the hollowness of the police investigation," he explains.

Sukant Goel, known for his performance in *Kaala Paani*, leads the film alongside veteran Sadhana Singh of *Nadiya Ke Paar* fame—making a return to the big screen in a leading role. Actor Rajit Kapur joins them as a Bengali detective, marking 28 years since his turn as Byomkesh Bakshi. Chakravorty describes working with the stellar cast as an intuitive, organic experience. "I was directing the story more than I was directing the actors. The rhythm was something they grasped instinctively from the script," he says.

> THE FILM STARTED AS A **CROWD-FUNDED PROJECT,** TRAVELLED THROUGH FOREIGN FILM CIRCUITS, AND IS NOW BEING RELEASED IN INDIA

Chakravorty has other scripts in the pipeline: a story centred on a cricket algorithm; a psychological thriller based on his 2015 novel *Split Second* and another murder mystery set in Assam. "I hope I get to make one of these," he concludes. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo